The Care Gaps Cheat Sheet

Plain words for gaps, backups and review triggers, and what to write down for each.

"Backup." "Covered." "Fine for now." Families use these words about Mom's support all the time, and each person means something a little different. This sheet gives eighteen words one plain meaning each, with what to jot down under it.

The entries with a number are defined from the public source listed at the bottom. The rest are the Family Care Roadmap's own working words. None of them is for sizing up Mom or her arrangement. They're for making sure the family means the same thing.

The help in place

Caregiver

A family member, partner, friend or neighbor who helps a person living at home. The neighbor who drives counts, and so do you. [1]

WRITE DOWN Everyone who helps, including the ones who'd say they don't do much.

Primary caregiver

The person who takes on most of the everyday caregiving responsibilities. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether anyone in the family fits that description today. "Nobody yet" is an answer.

Informal and formal caregivers

Informal caregivers are family members, friends and neighbors. Their help can be supplemented by formal caregivers and community services. [3]

WRITE DOWN Which kind each piece of Mom's support is.

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic personal tasks of everyday life: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who does each one. "Mom, on her own" is a complete entry.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Everyday tasks: housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing and cleaning up after meals, shopping, using the telephone, caring for pets, and responding to emergency alerts. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who does each one now: Mom, a helper, or both.

Meaningful activities

Activities that create a sense of purpose in daily life, such as hobbies, volunteer activities, or time with family and friends. [5]

WRITE DOWN What Mom would name, in her own words, and how she gets to each one.

Gaps and backups

Gap

Something Mom needs or wants help with that is done only some of the time, or by nobody yet. The word describes the arrangement, not Mom.

WRITE DOWN What happens now, in neutral words, with the date.

Depends on one person

A task one person does, with nobody else named who could. Sometimes called a dependency.

WRITE DOWN The task, the person, and "only them" or "not sure."

Backup

The person who would step in if the usual helper couldn't. The Family Caregiver Alliance's first step is to talk with that person about what might be needed and their willingness. [6]

WRITE DOWN The name, and which task they'd cover.

Agreed backup

A backup who has been asked and has said yes to a particular task. Also called a confirmed backup.

WRITE DOWN What they agreed to, and the date of the conversation.

Assumed backup

A backup the family names and nobody has asked yet. Also called an unconfirmed backup.

WRITE DOWN "Assumed," and who is going to ask.

Present need and future question

A present need is true this week. A future question is something that might come up later. The National Institute on Aging's first step for growing older at home is to think about the help needed now and the help that might be wanted in the future. [3]

WRITE DOWN "Today" or "later" beside each line, in two separate lists.

Capacity

How much a helper can do and is willing to do, by their own account. The National Institute on Aging says no one can be expected to do everything. [2]

WRITE DOWN What each helper says their part takes, in their words.

Keeping the page honest

Source and date

Who said it, and when. The same account passed along by three relatives is still one account.

WRITE DOWN A name and a date beside every line.

Unresolved question

Something nobody in the family knows yet. It's a question to ask. Not knowing is different from not covered.

WRITE DOWN The question, and who could answer it.

Professional-review question

A question the family can't settle by asking each other. One about Mom's health goes to her doctor. One about what her support has to cover goes to your care consultant.

WRITE DOWN The question in one sentence, and who it's for.

Review trigger

A change the family could notice that sends everyone back to the page. The CDC suggests updating a written care plan every year, or more often when health or medicines change. [7]

WRITE DOWN Three or four changes you'd actually notice: in Mom, in the people who help her, or in the house.

Care plan

A written summary of a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments, kept in one place. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom has one, who wrote it, and its date.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say which of them apply to Mom, whether any line on her page is a gap, or whether her support should change. That's for Mom and the people who assess her.

Ready for the next step?

You and the family now mean the same thing by "backup" and "gap." The care interview asks about the same areas in plain questions: it goes through Mom's daily life one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
3. National Institute on Aging, Aging in Place: Growing Older at Home

4. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
5. National Institute on Aging, Participating in Activities You Enjoy As You Age
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning
7. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

---

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.